

Obvious in First Games

By THE ASSOCIATED PRESS

The National League took a day off Good Friday after three days of action that produced 341,809 paid admissions, a new manager in Philadelphia and six men hitting .500 or better.

If there was one development that stood out above all others in the first few days it was recognition that Chuck Dressen had taken a firm hold in Milwaukee.

The appearance of Lew Burdette in the bullpen and the quick hook for Warren Spahn on opening day was a solid hint. As soon as Chuck hit Philadelphia for a weekend series, he announced that Spahn, too, would be in the bullpen if needed against the Phils. Juan Pizarro was out there Thursday.

Noting that Red Schoendienst had enough to do to supervise his own comeback after losing a year because of tuberculosis, Dressen appointed Eddie Mathews the "take charge guy" on the infield.

When Philadelphia started a left-handed pitcher, Dressen revealed he planned to platoon center and left. He brought in Mel Roach to replace Al Spangler in left and sent Felix Mantille to center instead of Bill Bruton. Of course, the left field situation may be changed when Wes Covington is ready for full time duty.

Philadelphia had its largest

opening crowd in two years, 32,038, to see acting Manager Andy Cohen make the right moves and beat Dressen. Frantic shifting of pitchers and pinch hitters finally brought up Joe Koppe. His single off Johnny Logan's glove won the game 5-4 in the 10th inning.

Although the hitting of Bobby Del Greco and the relief pitching of Don Cardwell were encouraging to Phil fans, the early bombing of Curt Simmons was a disappointment. Gene Mauch takes over as boss starting Saturday.

Pittsburgh, regarded as a singles-hitting club without much power, leads the league with a .333 club batting average, mostly on the strength of the 13-0 romp over Cincinnati Thursday afternoon. Roberto Clemente, the Pirates' right-fielder, is way out there with a .714 average and six runs batted in for two games. Dick Groat is hitting .625.

Cal McLish, a 19-game winner at Cleveland last year, failed in his first outing for Cincinnati, lasting less than three innings. However, the Reds are happy with Billy Martin's .500 average and the .429 hitting of rookie Tony Gonzalez, the new right fielder.

San Francisco's new park brought a flurry of conflicting reports. First, the wind was so tricky it was believed that nobody would hit a left field homer. Then

Thursday night Orlando Cepeda of the Giants connected and Ernie Banks hit a grand slammer into the cross wind and over the fence. Willie Mays, incidentally, is rolling along at a .500 clip.

The Chicago Cubs hoped for new power from Frank Thomas and they got a sample. After going hitless in seven trips, Thomas hit a three-run homer off Los Angeles' Larry Sherry Wednesday night and came through with three hits, including the winning double off the Giants' Billy O'Dell, Thursday night.

Los Angeles won a couple of one-run games and was shut out by the Cubs' Glen Hobbie. After the shutout, Manager Walter Alston benched center fielder Don Demeter and called on rookie Tom Davis in a search for more punch. Sherry lost his first as a starter but gets another try Sunday against St. Louis.

St. Louis was the only non-winner, dropping three straight, 3-1, 6-1 and 3-2. The pitching wasn't bad, except for Vinegar Bend Mizell, who was knocked out in the third inning by the Giants, and the wild pitch by relief pitcher Bob Duliba that lost Thursday night's game to the Dodgers.

Nobody has been hitting. Darly Spencer, the ex-Giant, is 0-for-11 and the club average is a dead .163.